

The greatest example of this is the success of Wikipedia! Despite having hundreds of thousands of contributors, the quality and accuracy of Wikipedia articles is believed to be as good as, or better than, other professionally written journals and online sources. Hence, in the field of collaborative software development, it is best to go by the adage ‘The more the merrier!’”

However, the role of a project owner is very crucial in an initiative like this. It is best to follow an agile model of product development. Project owners need to make sure that the project is broken down to the right level of granularity, so that each part can be assigned to an individual and there is no overlapping of responsibilities or duplication of work.

Talking about a desirable work culture in which this ‘open’ model can thrive, Variyam suggests, “The first step is to create awareness and generate enthusiasm amongst the community. Once that difficult first step is taken, a platform that makes the collaborative development process quite seamless needs to be created. It is very important to make sure that this platform integrates well with the various development environments, so that contributors and participants can work within the IDEs that they are most familiar and comfortable with.” Running a few pilot projects, and showcasing their

success and value, will help such a process and platform become mainstream.

‘Open’ is the way to go...

While the open source movement may have been started by volunteer programmers who simply loved programming, much has changed over the years. Large corporations and product companies today support this movement—and sooner or later, every product may well be expected to have a community edition, prophesies Variyam. Going forward, like the open source movement, this open platform also may mature into a standard and sustainable model for organisations to innovate faster, leveraging the vast pool of skill-sets and knowledge of employees on the one hand, and that of the open source community on the other. “This is because, slowly, everyone will realise the power of collaborative innovation. That is the true spirit of any open source community, and one that a FOSS eco-system should nurture,” affirms Variyam, signing off with a smile. 

By: Vandana Sharma

The author is an assistant editor at the EFY Group. Apart from writing on subjects like entrepreneurship and IT for businesses, she loves to read on a range of topics, which include religion and spirituality. She enjoys ‘meaningful’ fiction, too.



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